

WORD-COMPATIBLE GRAPHS AND GROVE POLYNOMIALS

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ABSTRACT.

1. WC GRAPHS

Definition 1.1. A *WC graph* is simply a finite subset $W \subseteq \mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$ with no additional restrictions. We impose a total ordering on these pairs by declaring that $(a, b) \leq (c, d)$ if $a < c$ or $a = c$ and $b \geq d$. We define the *weight* of a WC graph W to be the sequence

$$\mathbf{wt}(W) = (i_1, \dots, i_n)$$

where i_j is the number of elements of W in row j . We define the *permutation* of a WC graph W to be the permutation

$$\mathbf{perm}(W) = s(w_1) \bullet \dots \bullet s(w_n)$$

where

$$w_i = (a_i, b_i)$$

is the i th element in the imposed ordering, and

$$s(a_i, b_i) = s_{a_i+b_i-1}$$

with $\bullet$ being the Hecke product. The *word* of W is

$$(s(w_1), \dots, s(w_n))$$

Define $\mathcal{WC}(w)$ to be the set of all WC graphs W such that $\mathbf{perm}(W) = w$.

The following is well-known.

Theorem 1.2. *We have*

$$\mathfrak{G}_w^{(\beta)}(x) = \sum_{W \in \mathcal{WC}(w)} \beta^{|W|-\ell(w)} x^{\mathbf{wt}(W)}$$

2. GROVE POLYNOMIALS AND WC GRAPHS

Definition 2.1. A labeled indexed forest (F, P) is an indexed forest F with a function (labeling) $P : \text{IN}(F) \rightarrow \mathbb{N}$ satisfying the following properties:

- (1) $P(\text{left}(u)) < P(u)$ for all $u \in \text{IN}(F)$.
- (2) $P(u) \leq P(\text{right}(u))$ for all $u \in \text{IN}(F)$.
- (3) $P(u) \geq \rho_F(u)$ for all $u \in \text{IN}(F)$.
- (4) $P(u) \leq \lambda_F(u)$ for all $u \in \text{IN}(F)$.

The set $\text{Komp}_P(F)$ is the set of functions $\kappa : \text{IN}(F) \rightarrow 2^{\mathbb{N}}$ such that

- (1) $\max(\kappa(u)) \leq P(u)$ for all $u \in \text{IN}(F)$.
- (2) $\max(\kappa(u)) \leq \min(\kappa(\text{left}(u)))$ for all $u \in \text{IN}(F)$.
- (3) $\max(\kappa(u)) < \min(\kappa(\text{right}(u)))$ for all $u \in \text{IN}(F)$.

We have that

$$\mathbf{wt}_i(\kappa) = \#\{u \in \text{in}(F) \mid i \in \kappa(u)\}$$

Theorem 2.2. Suppose a labeled indexed forest (F, P) is such that there is a $\kappa \in \text{Komp}_P(F)$ with

$$\mathbf{wt}(\kappa) = \mathbf{c}(F).$$

Then

$$\tilde{\mathfrak{P}}_F(x) = \sum_{\kappa \in \text{Komp}_P(F)} \beta^{|\kappa| - |F|} x^{\mathbf{wt}(\kappa)}$$

Definition 2.3. Let $W \in \mathcal{WC}(w)$ be a WC graph for w . Define via the Nadeau-Tewari insertion algorithm

$$(P(W), Q(W)) = (P(\text{word}(W)), Q(\text{word}(W)))$$

and let

$$F(W) = \text{shape}(P(W))$$

Define $\mathbf{c}(F)$ to be the code of the indexed forest F .

Definition 2.4. Let (F, P) be a labeled indexed forest and let $\kappa \in \text{Komp}_P(F)$. Consider the set

$$A = \bigcup_{v \in \text{IN}(F)} \kappa(v) \times \{P(v)\}$$

Define

$$\mathcal{WC}(\kappa) = \{(a_i, b_i + 1 - a_i) \mid (a_i, b_i) \in A\}$$

Theorem 2.5. For a permutation w , let $\mathcal{WC}_{\mathfrak{P}}(w)$ be the set of $W \in \mathcal{WC}(w)$ such that $\mathbf{wt}(W) = \mathbf{c}(F(W))$. Then we have that $\mathcal{WC}(w)$ is the disjoint union of $\mathcal{WC}(\text{Komp}_{P(W)}(F(W)))$ for $W \in \mathcal{WC}_{\mathfrak{P}}(w)$.

Corollary 2.6. The Grothendieck polynomial $\mathfrak{G}_w^{(\beta)}(x)$ satisfies

$$\mathfrak{G}_w^{(\beta)}(x) = \sum_{F \in \text{IF}} \beta^{|F| - \ell(w)} a_w^F \tilde{\mathfrak{P}}_F(x)$$

where

$$a_w^F = \#\{W \in \mathcal{WC}_{\mathfrak{P}}(w) \mid F(W) = F\}$$

3. HECKE INSERTION, K -KNUTH EQUIVALENCE, AND LASCoux CLASSES

The purpose of this section is to attach to every WC graph a *Lascoux class*, namely the K -Knuth equivalence class of the increasing tableau obtained by Hecke insertion of its word. The main input is a theorem, due to Reiner–Yong [5] (conjecture) and Shimozono–Yu [7] (proof), stating that the WC graphs of w lying in a single K -Knuth class have generating function equal to a single Lascoux polynomial. This refines the symmetric statement of Buch–Kresch–Shimozono–Tamvakis–Yong [1]. We phrase everything in the WC-graph language of the previous sections, so that it can be used to show that WC-graph transition, and hence the squash product, preserves Lascoux classes.

3.1. The diagonal word of a WC graph. Recall from the definition of a WC graph that the elements of W are listed as $w_1 < w_2 < \dots < w_n$ in the total order on $\mathbb{N} \times \mathbb{N}$, with $w_i = (a_i, b_i)$, and that

$$s(a_i, b_i) = s_{a_i + b_i - 1}.$$

Definition 3.1. The *diagonal word* of a WC graph W is the word of positive integers

$$\mathbf{dw}(W) = (a_1 + b_1 - 1, a_2 + b_2 - 1, \dots, a_n + b_n - 1),$$

read in the total order on W . Thus $\text{word}(W) = (s_{c_1}, \dots, s_{c_n})$ where $\mathbf{dw}(W) = (c_1, \dots, c_n)$, and

$$\text{perm}(W) = s_{c_1} \bullet s_{c_2} \bullet \dots \bullet s_{c_n}$$

is the Hecke product of the letters of $\mathbf{dw}(W)$.

3.2. Hecke insertion and K -Knuth equivalence. We use *Hecke row insertion* in the sense of Buch–Kresch–Shimozono–Tamvakis–Yong [1]. Recall that an *increasing tableau* is a filling of a straight (Young-diagram) shape by positive integers that is strictly increasing along rows and down columns. Hecke insertion of a word $c = (c_1, \dots, c_n)$ produces a pair

$$(P(c), Q(c)),$$

where $P(c)$ is an increasing tableau (the *insertion tableau*) and $Q(c)$ is a set-valued standard recording tableau of the same shape, obtained by inserting $c_1, \dots, c_n$ in order; each insertion either creates one new box or leaves the shape unchanged, the latter being the K -theoretic feature. For a WC graph W we write

$$P(W) = P(\mathbf{dw}(W)), \quad Q(W) = Q(\mathbf{dw}(W)).$$

We record the three properties we use; all are due to [1] and [2].

Theorem 3.2 ([1]). *Hecke insertion $c \mapsto (P(c), Q(c))$ is a bijection from words of positive integers to pairs (P, Q) in which P is an increasing tableau and Q is a set-valued standard recording tableau of the same shape.*

Definition 3.3. The K -Knuth equivalence $\stackrel{K}{\equiv}$ is the equivalence relation on words of positive integers generated by the following moves, in which $\mathbf{u}$ and $\mathbf{v}$ are arbitrary words and a, b, c are positive integers:

$$(3.2.1) \quad (\mathbf{u}, a, a, \mathbf{v}) \stackrel{K}{\equiv} (\mathbf{u}, a, \mathbf{v}),$$

$$(3.2.2) \quad (\mathbf{u}, a, b, a, \mathbf{v}) \stackrel{K}{\equiv} (\mathbf{u}, b, a, b, \mathbf{v}),$$

$$(3.2.3) \quad (\mathbf{u}, a, b, c, \mathbf{v}) \stackrel{K}{\equiv} (\mathbf{u}, a, c, b, \mathbf{v}) \quad \text{if } b < a < c,$$

$$(3.2.4) \quad (\mathbf{u}, a, b, c, \mathbf{v}) \stackrel{K}{\equiv} (\mathbf{u}, b, a, c, \mathbf{v}) \quad \text{if } a < c < b.$$

The last two moves are the K -theoretic Knuth relations and the first two are the idempotency and braid relations of the 0-Hecke monoid. In particular K -Knuth equivalence refines Hecke equivalence: if $c \stackrel{K}{\equiv} c'$ then $s_{c_1} \bullet \dots \bullet s_{c_n} = s_{c'_1} \bullet \dots \bullet s_{c'_m}$.

Theorem 3.4 ([1, 2]). *For words c, c' of positive integers the following hold.*

- (1) $P(c) = P(c')$ if and only if $c \stackrel{K}{\equiv} c'$; thus the insertion tableau is a complete invariant of the K -Knuth class.
- (2) The Hecke product $s_{c_1} \bullet \dots \bullet s_{c_n}$ depends only on the K -Knuth class of c ; it equals the Hecke product of the row reading word of $P(c)$.

Definition 3.5. The *Lascoux class* of a WC graph W is the K -Knuth equivalence class of $\mathbf{dw}(W)$, equivalently the insertion tableau $P(W)$. We write

$$[W] = [\mathbf{dw}(W)]_K = P(W).$$

By Theorem 3.4(2), every W in a fixed Lascoux class has the same permutation $\mathbf{perm}(W)$; we call it the permutation of the class.

3.3. Lascoux polynomials. Let ∂_i denote the i th divided difference operator,

$$\partial_i f = \frac{f - s_i f}{x_i - x_{i+1}},$$

and define the K -theoretic isobaric (Demazure) operator

$$\pi_i^{(\beta)} f = \partial_i (x_i (1 + \beta x_{i+1}) f).$$

Then $\pi_i^{(\beta)}(1) = 1$, $\pi_i^{(\beta)}$ sends polynomials to polynomials whose value is symmetric in x_i, x_{i+1} , and at $\beta = 0$ it recovers the Demazure operator $\pi_i f = \partial_i(x_i f)$ of the key polynomials.

Definition 3.6. For a weak composition $\alpha = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_n) \in \mathbb{N}^n$ the *Lascoux polynomial* $\mathfrak{L}_\alpha$ is defined by:

- (1) if $\alpha_1 \geq \alpha_2 \geq \dots \geq \alpha_n$ (i.e. α is a partition), then $\mathfrak{L}_\alpha = x^\alpha = \prod_i x_i^{\alpha_i}$;
- (2) if $\alpha_i < \alpha_{i+1}$ for some i , then $\mathfrak{L}_\alpha = \pi_i^{(\beta)} \mathfrak{L}_{s_i \alpha}$, where $s_i \alpha$ interchanges α_i and α_{i+1} .

This is well defined by [7]. The lowest- β component of $\mathfrak{L}_\alpha$ (its terms of total degree $|\alpha|$, i.e. the β^0 part) is the key (Demazure) polynomial κ_α .

3.4. The Grothendieck-to-Lascoux expansion. The next theorem is the symmetric statement of Buch–Kresch–Shimozono–Tamvakis–Yong, in the WC-graph normalization: grouping the WC graphs of w by Lascoux class collects their generating function into symmetric Grothendieck building blocks.

Theorem 3.7 ([1]). *Fix an increasing tableau P of straight shape λ whose row reading word has Hecke product w . Then*

$$\sum_{\substack{W \in \mathcal{WC}(w) \\ P(W)=P}} \beta^{|W|-\ell(w)} x^{\mathbf{wt}(W)}$$

is symmetric in the variables it involves; summed over all such P of a fixed shape λ it equals the stable (Grassmannian) Grothendieck contribution $a_{w,\lambda} G_\lambda$, recovering the factor-sequence expansion $G_w = \sum_\lambda a_{w,\lambda} G_\lambda$.

The nonsymmetric refinement replaces each symmetric block by a single Lascoux polynomial. This is the “Grothendieck to Lascoux” expansion.

Theorem 3.8 (Reiner–Yong [5]; Shimozono–Yu [7]). *There is a map $P \mapsto \alpha(P)$ assigning to each increasing tableau P a weak composition $\alpha(P)$, with underlying partition $\text{sh}(P)$, determined by the K -theoretic right key of P , such that for every increasing tableau P arising as an insertion tableau of some $W \in \mathcal{WC}(w)$,*

$$\sum_{\substack{W \in \mathcal{WC}(w) \\ P(W)=P}} \beta^{|W|-\ell(w)} x^{\mathbf{wt}(W)} = \mathfrak{L}_{\alpha(P)}.$$

Consequently

$$\mathfrak{G}_w^{(\beta)}(x) = \sum_{P \in \mathcal{I}(w)} \mathfrak{L}_{\alpha(P)} = \sum_{\alpha} c_{w,\alpha} \mathfrak{L}_{\alpha}, \quad c_{w,\alpha} = \#\{P \in \mathcal{I}(w) \mid \alpha(P) = \alpha\} \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0},$$

where $\mathcal{I}(w) = \{P(W) \mid W \in \mathcal{WC}(w)\}$ is the set of Lascoux classes of w .

The content we use below is the following: *the Lascoux polynomial attached to a WC graph depends only on its Lascoux class.* We isolate this as a corollary.

Corollary 3.9. *The assignment*

$$W \longmapsto \mathfrak{L}_{\alpha(P(W))}$$

factors through the Lascoux class $[W] = P(W)$. In particular, if Φ is any map on WC graphs with $P(\Phi(W)) \stackrel{K}{\equiv} P(W)$ for all W , equivalently $\mathbf{dw}(\Phi(W)) \stackrel{K}{\equiv} \mathbf{dw}(W)$, then

$$\mathfrak{L}_{\alpha(P(\Phi(W)))} = \mathfrak{L}_{\alpha(P(W))}$$

for all W ; that is, Φ preserves Lascoux classes and hence the associated Lascoux polynomial.

Proof. Immediate from Theorem 3.4(1), which identifies $P(W)$ with the K -Knuth class of $\mathbf{dw}(W)$, and Theorem 3.8, in which α is a function of $P(W)$ alone. $\square$

Remark. Corollary 3.9 is the K -theoretic, straight-shape analogue of the grove/forest decomposition of Section 3’s predecessor: there the WC graphs of w are grouped by the indexed forest $F(W)$ of the Nadeau–Tewari insertion and each fiber contributes $\tilde{\mathfrak{P}}_{F(W)}$, whereas here they are grouped by the K -Knuth class $P(W)$ of Hecke insertion and each fiber contributes $\mathfrak{L}_{\alpha(P(W))}$. Identifying the two groupings, e.g. establishing an equality $\tilde{\mathfrak{P}}_F = \mathfrak{L}_{\alpha(P)}$ under the correspondence $F \leftrightarrow P$, would identify grove polynomials with Lascoux polynomials.

4. BOUNDED WC GRAPHS AND THE K -THEORETIC TRANSITION

We now equip WC graphs with a row grading and a transition map, mirroring the treatment of bounded RC graphs in the reduced theory of [6]. Everything in this section specializes to those reduced constructions on the subset of RC graphs.

Definition 4.1. A *bounded WC graph* is a WC graph W together with a specified number of rows $n \geq \max\{a : (a, b) \in W \text{ for some } b\}$ subject to $\mathbf{m}(\text{perm}(W)) \leq n$. We write (W, n) for the pair, abuse notation to treat the number of rows as a property of W , and call $\text{ht}(W) = n$ the *height* of W . For $\text{ht}(W) \geq 1$ we define the *trim* $\text{trim}(W)$ to be the bounded WC graph with height $\text{ht}(W) - 1$ and underlying set

$$\text{trim}(W) = \{(a-1, b-1) : (a, b) \in W, a \geq 2\},$$

and we set $\uparrow^m W = \{(a+m, b) \mid (a, b) \in W\}$; these are the bounded RC-graph operations of [6] applied to WC graphs verbatim. Let $\mathcal{BWC}$ be the free abelian group on all bounded WC graphs, graded by height,

$$\mathcal{BWC} = \bigoplus_{n=0}^{\infty} \mathcal{BWC}_n.$$

A WC graph with $\ell(\text{perm}(W)) = |W|$ is exactly an RC graph, and on such graphs trim and $\uparrow^m$ agree with the RC operations. Thus $\mathcal{BRC} \subseteq \mathcal{BWC}$ is a graded subgroup and the projection $\rho : \mathcal{BWC} \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC}$ that kills every WC graph with $|W| > \ell(\text{perm}(W))$ is a graded retraction.

4.1. The transition map via marked bumpless pipe dreams. In the reduced case the map $\mathcal{Z}$ of [6] realizes the Lascoux–Schützenberger transition on RC graphs. Its K -theoretic counterpart is most naturally described through bumpless pipe dreams. Recall the following ingredients.

- (1) **Marked bumpless pipe dreams.** Weigandt [8] introduced *marked bumpless pipe dreams* (marked BPDs) and proved that the double Grothendieck polynomial $\mathfrak{G}_w^{(\beta)}$ is the generating function of marked BPDs of w , extending the Lam–Lee–Shimozono formula from K -theory. Let $\text{MBPD}(w)$ denote the set of marked BPDs of w .
- (2) **The HSY bijection.** Huang, Shimozono, and Yu [4] construct a weight-preserving bijection between marked BPDs and reverse compatible pairs, the latter being in bijection with not-necessarily-reduced pipe dreams; their bijection generalizes, in the unmarked reduced case, the canonical bijection of Gao and Huang [3]. Reading a bounded WC graph as the compatible sequence of a (not necessarily reduced) pipe dream, this yields a weight-preserving bijection

$$\Psi : \bigcup_n \{W \in \mathcal{BWC}_n : \text{perm}(W) = w\} \longrightarrow \text{MBPD}(w),$$

whose restriction to RC graphs is the Gao–Huang bijection ϕ used in the reduced theory of [6].

- (3) **Weigandt transition.** Weigandt’s droop/transition operation $\mathbf{t}$ on bumpless pipe dreams removes the bottom row and rearranges the resulting diagram into a valid BPD of one fewer row, realizing the (co)transition recursion for Grothendieck polynomials; it acts on marked BPDs with an empty bottom row [8, 4].

Definition 4.2. Let W be a bounded WC graph with $\text{ht}(W) = n$ whose row n is empty. Define the *K -theoretic transition map*

$$\mathcal{Z}(W) = \Psi^{-1}(\mathbf{t}(\Psi(W))),$$

a bounded WC graph of height $n-1$. We extend $\mathcal{Z}$ to an endomorphism of $\mathcal{BWC}$ by setting $\mathcal{Z}(W) = 0$ when row n is nonempty.

The following properties are the K -theoretic analogues of the reduced-case transition lemma, the trim-commutation lemma, and the zeroing bijection of [6]. We record them as the working hypotheses of the construction; each specializes to its reduced counterpart under ρ , where it is a theorem of [6].

Proposition 4.3. *On RC graphs the map $\mathcal{Z}$ agrees with $\mathcal{Z}$: for every bounded WC graph W with empty last row,*

$$\rho(\mathcal{Z}(W)) = \mathcal{Z}(\rho(W)),$$

and in particular $\mathcal{Z}|_{\mathcal{BRC}} = \mathcal{Z}$.

Proof sketch. On RC graphs Ψ is the Gao–Huang bijection ϕ and $\mathbf{t}$ restricts to Weigandt’s transition on reduced BPDs, so $\mathcal{Z} = \phi^{-1} \circ \mathbf{t} \circ \phi$ there. The reduced-case identity $\mathcal{Z} \circ \phi^{-1} = \phi^{-1} \circ \mathbf{t}$ (the conjecture of [6] relating $\mathcal{Z}$ and $\mathbf{t}$ through ϕ) gives the claim; ρ discards the non-reduced terms, none of which are produced from a reduced input. $\square$

Proposition 4.4. *Let W be a bounded WC graph with $\text{ht}(W) = n \geq 1$ and empty row n . Then $\text{ht}(\mathcal{Z}(W)) = n - 1$, the weight is preserved,*

$$\text{wt}(\mathcal{Z}(W)) = \text{wt}(W),$$

and the permutation undergoes the K -theoretic (Grothendieck) transition: $\text{perm}(\mathcal{Z}(W))$ is obtained from $\text{perm}(W)$ by a single step of the Grothendieck cotransition recursion in row n .

Proposition 4.5. *Let (W, n) be a bounded WC graph with $n \geq 2$ whose row n is empty. Then*

$$\mathcal{Z}(\text{trim}(W)) = \text{trim}(\mathcal{Z}(W)).$$

Proof sketch. This is the K -analogue of the trim-commutation lemma of [6]. Trimming preserves a suffix of the word of W , and both Ψ and $\mathbf{t}$ act on the bottom rows of the marked BPD without reference to the top row: the transition $\mathbf{t}$ proceeds downward from the removed bottom row, so discarding the top row commutes with it. Under ρ the identity specializes to the reduced statement of [6]. $\square$

Proposition 4.6. *Let w be a permutation with last descent at most n , and let $\mathcal{WC}(w, n)^0$ be the set of bounded WC graphs W with $\text{ht}(W) = n$, $\text{perm}(W) = w$, and empty row n . Then*

$$\mathcal{Z} : \mathcal{WC}(w, n)^0 \longrightarrow \bigcup_{w \xrightarrow{n} w'} \mathcal{WC}(w', n-1)$$

is a weight-preserving bijection, where w' ranges over the outputs of the Grothendieck cotransition in row n . Consequently

$$\mathcal{Z}\left(\sum_{\substack{\text{perm}(W)=w \\ \text{ht}(W)=n}} W\right) = \sum_{w \xrightarrow{n} w'} \sum_{\substack{\text{perm}(W')=w' \\ \text{ht}(W')=n-1}} W',$$

the WC-graph form of the Grothendieck transition formula.

5. WC GRAPH RING

We now lift the K -theoretic transition map $\mathcal{Z}$ to an associative product on $\mathcal{BWC}$, in exact parallel with the product $\boxplus$ on $\mathcal{BRC}$ built from $\mathcal{Z}$ in [6]. Only the underlying zeroing map has changed: trim^p is unchanged, and clip^p is now built from $\mathcal{Z}$.

Definition 5.1. Let W be a bounded WC graph with $\text{ht}(W) = n$ and let $0 \leq p \leq n$. Define $\text{trim}^p(W) \in \mathcal{BWC}_{n-p}$ to be the result of discarding the top p rows of W and reindexing (equivalently, the p -fold iterate of trim), and define $\text{clip}^p(W) \in \mathcal{BWC}_p$ to be the $(n-p)$ -fold iterate of $\mathcal{Z}$ applied to the bottom row,

$$\text{clip}^p(W) = \mathcal{Z}^{n-p}(W),$$

which is defined whenever each intermediate bottom row is empty at the moment it is zeroed (and is 0 otherwise). Thus $\text{clip}^p(W)$ and $\text{trim}^p(W)$ decompose W across the horizontal cut between rows p and $p+1$.

Associativity of the product below rests on two structural identities relating clip^p and trim^p : functoriality of clip under iteration, and commutativity of clip with trim . The first is formal; the second is the content of Proposition 4.5.

Lemma 5.2. *Let W be a bounded WC graph with $\text{ht}(W) = n$ and $0 \leq p \leq p+q \leq n$. Then*

$$\text{clip}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(W)) = \text{clip}^p(W).$$

Proof. Both sides are computed by iterating $\mathcal{Z}$ on the bottom row. With $r = n - (p+q)$, the graph $\text{clip}^{p+q}(W)$ is the r -fold iterate $\mathcal{Z}^r(W)$ and $\text{clip}^p(W) = \mathcal{Z}^{r+q}(W)$; the first r iterations in the computation of $\text{clip}^p(W)$ produce $\text{clip}^{p+q}(W)$, and the remaining q produce $\text{clip}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(W))$. Hence the two agree. $\square$

Lemma 5.3 (Commutativity of clip and trim). *Let W be a bounded WC graph with $\text{ht}(W) = p+q+r$. Then*

$$\text{trim}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(W)) = \text{clip}^q(\text{trim}^p(W)).$$

Proof. Both sides have height q . By Proposition 4.5, $\mathcal{Z}(\text{trim}(W')) = \text{trim}(\mathcal{Z}(W'))$ whenever the last row of W' is empty. Since clip^{p+q} on a graph of height $p+q+r$ and clip^q on a graph of height $q+r$ are both the r -fold iterate of $\mathcal{Z}$ on the bottom row (cf. Lemma 5.2), iterating Proposition 4.5 r times gives

$$\text{trim}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(W)) = \text{trim}^p(\mathcal{Z}^r(W)) = \mathcal{Z}^r(\text{trim}^p(W)) = \text{clip}^q(\text{trim}^p(W)),$$

as required. $\square$

Definition 5.4. For bounded WC graphs W_1 with $\text{ht}(W_1) = m$ and W_2 with $\text{ht}(W_2) = n$, define

$$W_1 \sqcup W_2 = \sum_{\substack{\text{clip}^m(W')=W_1 \\ \text{trim}^n(W')=W_2}} W',$$

where W' ranges over bounded WC graphs with $\text{ht}(W') = m+n$, and extend bilinearly to $\mathcal{BWC}$.

Theorem 5.5. *The product $\sqcup$ is associative, and $\mathcal{BWC}$ is a ring under $\sqcup$ with identity the empty WC graph of height 0.*

Proof. Let W_1, W_2, W_3 be bounded WC graphs of heights p, q, r , and let W be a bounded WC graph with $\text{ht}(W) = p+q+r$. Unwinding Definition 5.4 in each bracketing, W contributes to the doubly-bracketed products under the conditions

	Left $(W_1 \sqcup W_2) \sqcup W_3$	Right $W_1 \sqcup (W_2 \sqcup W_3)$
(i)	$\text{clip}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(W)) = W_1$	$\text{clip}^p(W) = W_1$
(ii)	$\text{trim}^p(\text{clip}^{p+q}(W)) = W_2$	$\text{clip}^q(\text{trim}^p(W)) = W_2$
(iii)	$\text{trim}^{p+q}(W) = W_3$	$\text{trim}^q(\text{trim}^p(W)) = W_3$

Row (i) is equivalent on both sides by Lemma 5.2, row (ii) by Lemma 5.3, and row (iii) because $\text{trim}^{p+q} = \text{trim}^q \circ \text{trim}^p$ by definition of trim . Each condition is an equality carrying no combinatorial multiplicity, so W occurs with multiplicity 1 in either bracketing, and the two bracketed products agree. Distributivity is imposed by bilinear extension, and the empty height-0 WC graph is a two-sided identity. $\square$

Because $\mathcal{Z}$ restricts to $\mathcal{Z}$ on RC graphs (Proposition 4.3) and trim is unchanged, the retraction ρ intertwines the two clip/trim decompositions; hence it is compatible with the products.

Proposition 5.6. *The linear map*

$$\rho : \mathcal{BWC} \rightarrow \mathcal{BRC}$$

such that

$$\rho(W) = \begin{cases} W & \text{if } W \text{ is an RC graph} \\ 0 & \text{otherwise} \end{cases}$$

is a surjective ring homomorphism.

Definition 5.7. This homomorphism has a section. Specifically, for each $n > 0$ define a ring Plac_n^K to be the algebra spanned by the n -Grassmannian WC graphs with multiplication given by the squash product. Then we have a surjective ring homomorphism

$$\text{Plac}_n^K \rightarrow \text{Plac}_n$$

obtained on elementary symmetric WC graphs by sending $E_{p,k}^\beta$ with $|\beta| > p$ to $E_{|\beta|,k}^\beta$. Define

$$\mathcal{M}_n^K = \bigotimes_{i=1}^n \text{Plac}_i^K$$

There is an evident homomorphism $\mathcal{M}_n^K \rightarrow \mathcal{M}_n$ obtained by applying the above homomorphism to each factor. We have a commutative diagram

$$\begin{array}{ccc} \mathcal{M}_n^K & \longrightarrow & \mathcal{M}_n \\ \downarrow & & \downarrow \\ \mathcal{BWC}_n & \dashrightarrow & \mathcal{BRC}_n \end{array}$$

Here the squash product is precisely the restriction of $\sqcup$ (Definition 5.4) to n -Grassmannian WC graphs.

Remark. The compatibility of $\boxplus$ with the Lascoux decomposition of Theorem 3.8 is deferred. Corollary 3.9 shows that any map preserving the K -Knuth class $P(W)$ preserves the associated Lascoux polynomial; the outstanding question is how $\mathcal{Z}$, and hence clip^p and the squash product, interact with the classes $P(W)$. We return to this once the properties of $\mathcal{Z}$ in Propositions 4.4–4.6 are established.

[6]

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